We had to fight Varanasi to send out a message—we wanted to show we were not scared of Modi,' he countered.

The BJP, too, wanted to prove a point. Worried by the AAP factor at the start of the year, they now wanted to teach him a lesson. 'The real battle in Varanasi was always as to who would come second and who would lose their deposit. We wanted Kejriwal to lose his deposit, that was our goal,' the BJP's Kohli told me later.

Modi was never going to lose Varanasi. The big question was what would be the margin of the win. I remember meeting a few Delhi-based social activists who were campaigning against Modi. 'He can be defeated—you media people have all been bought over by him,' one vociferous lady told me angrily. I protested the accusation but realized I was never going to win this debate. Wearing ideological blinkers, I fear, can lead even rational people to think irrationally at election time.

A more logical explanation for the Modi wave in Varanasi was provided to me by the owner of Keshav Paan Bhandar, the city's most famous paan shop. As he lovingly prepared a *meetha* paan for me, I asked him why he was voting for Modi. '*Bhaisaab, agar woh pradhan mantri bante hain, toh Varanasi ka kuch to bhala hoga'*

(If Modi becomes PM, Varanasi will at least benefit in some way).

Like many other parts of India, Varanasi, too, was living on hope. In the land of Bismillah Khan and its 'Ganga–Jamuni *tehzeeb*', as they would say in Urdu, '*Ummeed par duniya kaayam hai!'* (The world lives on hope.)

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The election in Amethi took place on 7 May. Varanasi was scheduled for the 12th. Only forty-one of the 543 seats were now left in what had been an agonizingly long nine-phase election. It was into this last stretch that the BJP now poured its entire might. 'This was now carpet-bombing in a multiple of ten,' is how one BJP leader summed up the last week of the campaign.